

MAN-PORTABLE ANTITANK WEAPONS (1940–42)

Portable antitank weapons continued to be developed as World War II progressed. Some systems, such as the PIAT, relied on a spring-driven firing pin to ignite a propellant charge attached to the base of a self-propelled projectile. Others, such as the bazooka, released projectiles with solid rocket motors. In both cases, when the projectile met its target, a shaped-charge warhead helped to focus the effect of the explosive's energy so that it could penetrate armor effectively. This made launchers lighter and easier to make. As tanks evolved and their armor became thicker, older designs of antitank rifle, such as the PTRD, became obsolete, as they could rarely knock out a tank even at a very short range.



▼ PANZERBÜSCHE 39 ANTITANK RIFLE

Date 1940

Origin Germany

Barrel 3½ft (1.08m)

Caliber 7.92 × 94mm

Armor penetration 1in (25mm) at 330 yards (300m)

The Panzerbüsche 39 relied on its very high muzzle velocity and tungsten-cored bullet to penetrate enemy armor. It was, however, expensive to manufacture, and was only produced in small numbers.

